

*goodness sakes! Mary looked straight into the young man's eyes as he approached, ready to defend her honor and her marriage, ready to break the young man's heart.*

*"Excuse me," he said, "I couldn't help but notice you in the store." Mary's direct gaze didn't waver, though her brain was rapidly trying to come up with a way to let him down easy.*

*"My mom is about your age. I was trying to come up with a perfect birthday gift for her and wondered where you got that great coupon box . . ."*

I took great pride in "doing it all" during my years of avid couponing, including the well-organized shopping sprees that made me the local Coupon Queen. Even before beginning this book, I'd considered the fact that extreme couponing has been a part of my life for so long that I might have lost some objectivity regarding the intrinsic value of avid couponing and stockpiling.

An interesting thing happened as I was delving into the history of couponing and refunding, and interviewing other extreme couponers. I found myself abandoning some of my long-held couponing practices. I left my coupon binder at home more often and changed some of my own extreme shopping habits. I stopped purchasing coupons. I no longer traveled great distances for a single good deal, nor did I lament missing a Target "75% off" post-holiday sale. I could actually pass over some super deals without hyperventilating. The change was gradual, but my husband, my "deal-hunting partner" of over thirty years noticed. I didn't completely abandon my use of coupons, but it was an eye-opening experience to view